found in 1957 that, over the previous year, the Chinese had quietly built a highway between Tibet and Xinjiang that went right through Aksai Chin. The Indian government did not even know about such a major project being constructed on territory that it claimed!

Matters really heated up from there. An official Chinese magazine published a map in 1958 that showed large parts of Ladakh and the North East Frontier Agency (NEFA) as part of Chinese territory. If any reader was not convinced about the importance of cartography in history, I hope they have changed their mind by now. Nehru wrote angry letters to Chou En-Lai. The Chinese responded that Aksai Chin had always been Chinese territory and that the McMohan Line was not valid as it had been concluded between British imperialists and the Tibet Region of China (implying that a mere province had no business negotiating the national boundary). In the middle of all the letter-writing, in March 1959, the Dalai Lama fled to India via Tawang and was granted asylum.

The Chinese had long claimed suzerainty over Tibet and had occasionally exercised it. However, as the Mughals had discovered in the seventeenth century, the hostile terrain made it very difficult to enforce control. Thus, Tibet had been effectively independent for a long time when the communists invaded and annexed it in October 1950. Nehru had, at that time, preferred to look away despite Sardar Patel's warning, just a few weeks before he died, that 'In the guise of ideological expansion lies concealed racial, national or historical claims'.[13]

By the time the Dalai Lama arrived in India, there were regular skirmishes between Indian and Chinese border patrols. Alarm bells were going off everywhere. General Thimayya, the army chief, repeatedly requested an equipment upgrade and the redeployment of troops to the China border. Some units of the army were still armed with .303 Enfield pea-shooters from the First World War. Yet, Prime Minister Nehru and Defence Minister Krishna Menon disregarded the warnings. When asked to introduce Belgian FN4 automatic rifles, Menon retorted that he did not want 'NATO arms' in the country. Dogma came first.